

Achalasia Cardia

Headings

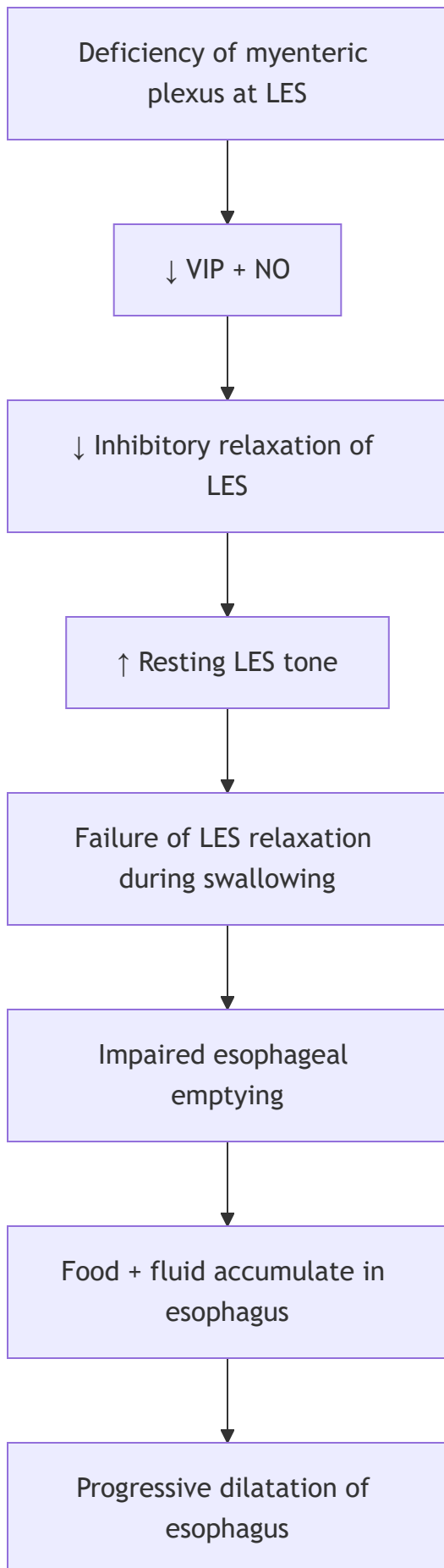
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1. Definition

Achalasia = failure of relaxation

It is a disorder in which the **lower esophageal sphincter (LES)** fails to relax adequately during **deglutition**, causing impaired emptying of the esophagus.

2. Pathophysiology



Key point

↓ Myenteric inhibitory neurons → ↓ VIP + NO → LES fails to relax
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3. Clinical / Diagnostic Features

Feature	Finding
LES	High resting tone + incomplete relaxation
Esophagus	Food and fluid accumulation
Result	Massive dilatation
Barium meal X-ray	Narrowed lower end with dilated esophagus → rat-tail appearance
Esophagoscopy	Retained food and fluid

4. Treatment

Mechanical

→ **Pneumatic dilatation** of LES

Severe cases

→ **Myotomy** — surgical weakening/incision of esophageal muscle

Drug treatment

→ **Botulinum toxin injection into LES**

Botulinum toxin → ↓ ACh release → LES relaxation

★ One-line recall

Achalasia

↓ Myenteric plexus → ↓ VIP/NO → LES fails to relax → Esophageal dilatation

Viva: “*What is the characteristic X-ray appearance?*” → **Rat-tail appearance.**